

National Management Group Communiqué

High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (H7) – 23 May 2024

A response plan for High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza (H7) in Victoria was endorsed on 23 May 2024 by the National Management Group (NMG). The NMG comprises all Australian governments and affected industries made up of the Australian Chicken Meat Federation, Australian Duck Meat Association and Australian Eggs Limited.

In late May 2024, an outbreak of High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza H7 was detected in poultry on a commercial free-range and caged egg farm near Meredith in Victoria. The disease has since been detected on a second farm near Terang.

Agriculture Victoria is responding to the detection and is working with property owners and industry to undertake appropriate response activities.

Avian influenza is a serious disease of poultry, and can cause a high mortality rate in production birds.

The H7 virus is not a risk to the public as it rarely affects humans unless there is direct and close contact with sick birds.

There are no food safety issues identified; properly cooked chicken meat and eggs remain safe to eat.

This is not the High Pathogenicity Avian Influenza H5N1 strain that has gained worldwide attention – nor is it closely related to that strain.

If you notice a number of sick or dead birds, contact the Emergency Animal Disease Hotline on 1800 675 888. If you discover large numbers of sick or dead wild birds, you need to report this to the hotline so it can be investigated.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/national-management-group-communicue-23-may-2024-h7>